

severe caution. History is certainly not a place to theorize or derive general knowledge, nor is it meant to help in the future, without some caution. We can get negative confirmation from history, which is invaluable, but we get plenty of illusions of knowledge along with it.

This brings me back once again to Menodotus and the treatment of the turkey problem and how to not be a sucker for the past. The empirical doctor's approach to the problem of induction was to *know* history without theorizing from it. Learn to read history, get all the knowledge you can, do not frown on the anecdote, but do not draw any causal links, do not try to reverse engineer too much—but if you do, do not make big scientific claims. Remember that the empirical skeptics had respect for custom: they used it as a default, a basis for action, but not for more than that. This clean approach to the past they called *epilogism*.^{*}

But most historians have another opinion. Consider the representative introspection *What Is History?* by Edward Hallett Carr. You will catch him explicitly pursuing causation as a central aspect of his job. You can even go higher up: Herodotus, deemed to be the father of the subject, defined his purpose in the opening of his work:

To preserve a memory of the deeds of the Greeks and barbarians, “and in particular, beyond everything else, to give a *cause* [emphasis mine] to their fighting one another.”

You see the same with all theoreticians of history, whether Ibn Khaldoun, Marx, or Hegel. The more we try to turn history into anything other than an enumeration of accounts to be enjoyed with minimal theorizing, the more we get into trouble. Are we so plagued with the narrative fallacy?[†]

We may have to wait for a generation of skeptical-empiricist historians capable of understanding the difference between a forward process and a reverse one.

Just as Popper attacked the historicists in their making claims about the future, I have just presented the weakness of the historical approach in knowing the *past* itself.

After this discussion about future (and past) blindness, let us see what to do about it. Remarkably, there are extremely practical measures we can take. We will explore this next.

^{*} Yogi Berra might have a theory of epilogism with his saying, “You can observe a lot by just watching.”

[†] While looking at the past it would be a good idea to resist naïve analogies. Many people have compared the United States today to Ancient Rome, both from a military standpoint (the destruction of Carthage was often invoked as an incentive for the destruction of enemy regimes) and from a social one (the endless platitudinous warnings of the upcoming decline and fall). Alas, we need to be extremely careful in transposing knowledge from a simple environment that is closer to type 1, like the